



KAYAPO

SPEAKING TO THE WORLD

LIKE MANY NATIVE PEOPLE IN THE AMAZON BASIN, the Kayapo Indians are afraid for their rain-forest home, which is steadily being destroyed by the reckless harvesting of its trees. To communicate their fears to the world, they have appointed a unique messenger—a chief called Raoni who travels tirelessly from continent to continent pleading their case. Certainly, Raoni's appearance makes him hard to ignore: on his head is a circle of perfectly matched parrot feathers, handed down through generations like a precious crown. Dominating his face completely, though, is his huge lower lip, stretched since childhood over a series of bigger and bigger balsawood discs. For the Kayapo, this extraordinary feature is an ancient symbol of strength, a quality they value highly. Now, in order to stop the destruction of the rain forest, they need all the strength they can gather.

